Chapter 18 – The Caste System

"My method is atheism. I find the atheistic outlook provides a favorable background for cosmopolitan practices. Acceptance of atheism at once pulls down caste and religious barriers between man and man. There is no longer a Hindu, a Muslim or a Christian. All are human beings."

(Gora, *An Atheist with Gandhi*)

As India underwent political, economic, and religious changes over the millennia, an invisible hierarchy was established that persisted despite foreign rule, internal warfare, agricultural and pastoral developments, and the establishment of Buddhism: it was the caste system. Like the formal and informal class divisions of modern societies—lower-class, middle-class, upper-class—castes defined economic realities for India's people, though it was initially more definitive of the roles each person played within the community. According to Hindu literature, the caste system divides Hindus into groups based on their work and their duty, or karma and dharma. These groups contain Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras.

Hindus believe that these caste groupings came from Brahma himself, the God of creation, and therefore each of the groups is based on a body part of Brahma. The most valuable and therefore the most influential people were Brahmans, who came from Brahma's head. These are intellectuals and teachers. Beneath these are the Kshatriyas, from Brahma's arms. They are the warriors and kings. Next are the Vaishyas, from Brahma's thighs, responsible for trade. From Brahma's feet came the Shudras, responsible for manual labor. The Dalits, or untouchables, were on the lowest rung of the hierarchical ladder; they were left the job of cleaning toilets and sweeping streets. Technically speaking, the Dalits aren't even in the caste system but exist outside of it.

Though it's easy to imagine such a system being economically viable in the prehistorical days when India's villages and towns only had so many roles to fill, these divisions were actually quite psychologically influential. The castes lived apart in separate sections of the community, each avoiding the other's wells and public spaces. People married only within their caste and did not eat or drink with members of the others. When Muslim conquerors